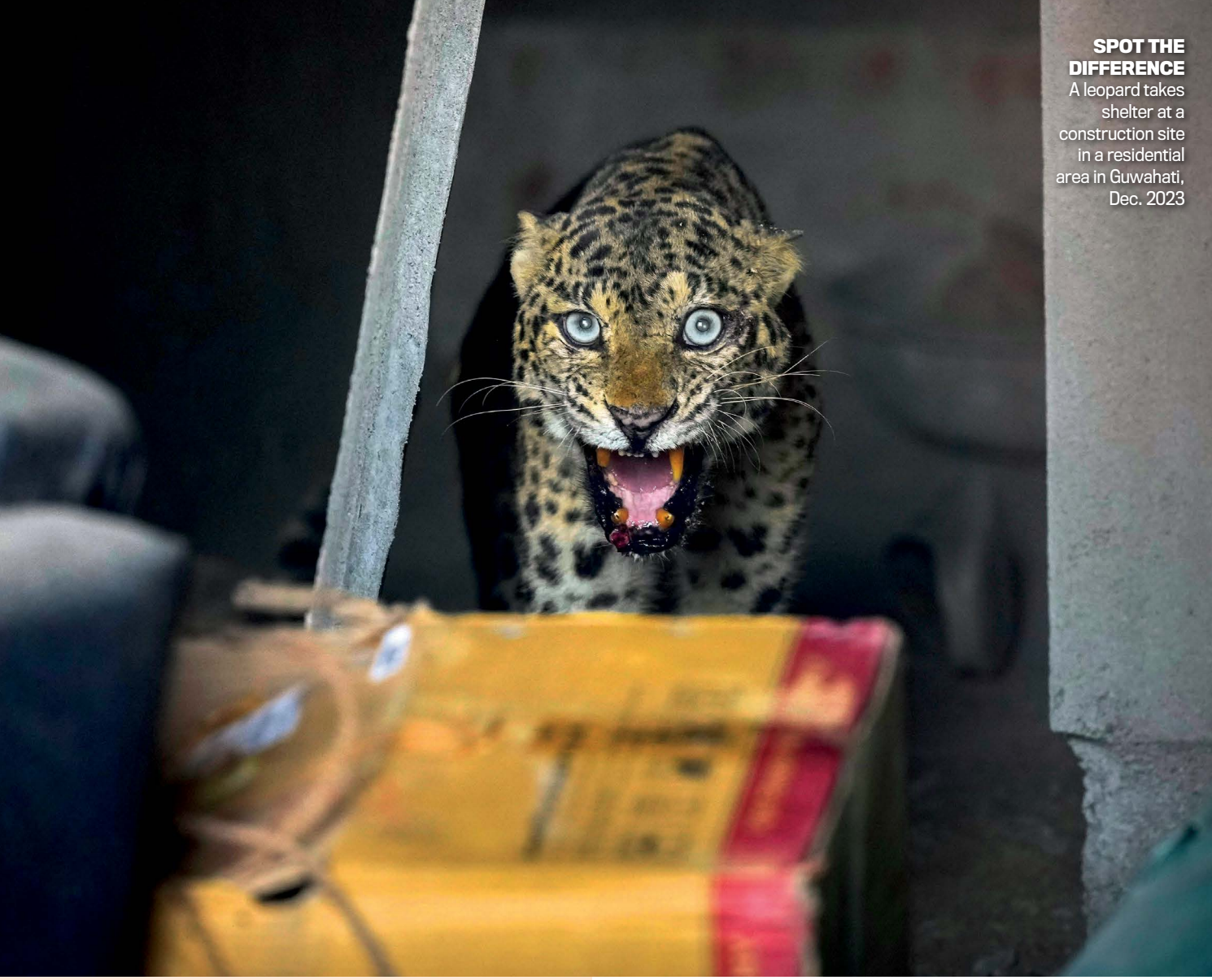


SPOT THE DIFFERENCE
A leopard takes shelter at a construction site in a residential area in Guwahati, Dec. 2023

THE BODY COUNT

- A tribal woman was attacked and killed by a tiger in Wayanad on January 24, sparking protests. The 'man-eater' was later found dead
- In one week in early February, encounters with wild elephants left five people dead in Kerala-Tamil Nadu's ghats section
- Tamil Nadu alone lost 80 lives to wild animal attacks in 2024-25. The state's 4,235 crop damage incidents and 259 livestock deaths are also typical for the forested trijunction of TN, Kerala and Karnataka
- Uttar Pradesh's Bahraich district saw several villages terrorised by wolf attacks in 2024, killing 10 and leaving over 30 injured; a large area around MP's Khandwa and Sehore towns saw jackal attacks
- Kerala reported 11 deaths in 2023-24 and eight in 2024-25 owing to wild boar attacks
- Maharashtra had an astounding 117 human deaths due to tiger attacks in 2022 and '23, mostly around Tadoba

jungles, with mountain streams flowing past. Tamil Nadu has had 80 human deaths in 2024-25 already, the highest in five fiscal years, in encounters with wildlife; not counting 4,235 incidents of crop damage, 259 livestock deaths. Imagine each number as a moment of terror unfolding in real life, and you get a measure of just how and how much human economies are encroaching on the jungle all over India. And producing new interactions.

But that common framing misses a new and unpredictable pattern, one that may seem nightmarish at first. Call it a kind of animal revanchism: reclaiming of old territory, which may include long-urbanised spaces. Between March and September 2024, a pack of wolves set upon humans, mostly children, in Uttar Pradesh's Bahraich town. Toll: 10 killed, over 30 injured. As the attacks intensified, six wolves were captured. Around the same time, Madhya Pradesh towns like Salkanpur, Khandwa and Sehore, just outside Bhopal—a large area with a radius of 200 km—came alive with jackal attacks. The distinguishing feature: increasing